

Nevada range (see left) at an altitude of 7,500 ft (2,300 m). One of the world's finest examples of columnar basalt, the vertical, hexagonal columns of the Postpile tower 60 ft (18 m) above the valley side; some are more than 3 ft (1 m) in diameter. They were created 100,000–80,000 years ago when a huge outpouring of lava flooded the area to a depth of 410 ft (125 m), later cooling and solidifying. Glacial action subsequently eroded the basalt, exposing the columns in all their glory.

The Coast Ranges

Location Between western British Columbia and southwest California, western North America

Stretching at least 1,680 miles (2,700 km), this series of mountain ranges runs roughly parallel to



the Pacific coast from the Coast Mountains of British Columbia to the Transverse Ranges in southern California. The Olympic Mountains in Washington State are the most spectacular of the ranges. The folded and faulted igneous, metamorphic, and sedimentary mountains are the product of complex tectonic plate movements. Subduction produces volcanism in some regions, while major faults, such as the San Andreas, are active elsewhere.

Parícutin

Location The state of Michoacan, west central Mexico

After several days of small earthquakes and underground rumbling, a crack opened up in a farmer's field in February 1943 and began spewing ash, lava, and pyroclastic bombs. Within 24 hours, its cinder cone was 165 ft (50 m) high, and by the time the eruptions stopped in 1952 the top of the volcano was 1,391 ft (424 m) above the surrounding landscape. Two nearby villages were evacuated before being engulfed in lava. Although Parícutin is now extinct, the crater is still hot and emits steam when rain falls.

Volcán de Colima

Location Mostly in the state of Jalisco, west central Mexico

This massive stratovolcano is one of the most active in North America, having erupted more than 40 times since 1576, most recently in 2017. Eruptions produce flows of viscous lava, explosions of pyroclastic material, and enormous ash clouds. With 300,000 people living nearby, it is one of the most dangerous volcanoes on the continent. Volcán de Colima's summit rises 12,631 ft (3,850 m) above sea level.

► STEAM RISING FROM VOLCÁN DE COLIMA

